

Sūtra of the Youth Similes

Kumārādṛṣṭānta Sūtra · Toh 296 · Derge Kangyur

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The Sūtra of the Youth Similes, known in Sanskrit as the Kumārādṛṣṭānta Sūtra and in Tibetan as the Gzhon nu dpe'i mdo, is a discourse in which the Buddha responds to the skepticism of King Prasenajit of Kosala, who doubts that so young a teacher could have attained the highest awakening. The Buddha addresses this doubt through a series of similes illustrating that youth is no barrier to greatness or danger, gently but firmly establishing the authenticity of his enlightenment in dialogue with the king at Jeta Grove in Śrāvastī. It belongs to the sūtra literature of the Kangyur and is classified as Toh 296, placed among the individual discourses that make up the general collection of canonical teachings attributed directly to the Buddha.

In the language of India: Kumārādṛṣṭānta Sūtra. In the language of Tibet: the Sūtra of the Youth Similes. Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was traveling through the land of Kosala and came to Śrāvastī, where he dwelt in the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta, in the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada.

Now King Prasenajit of Kosala heard that the ascetic Gautama had been traveling through the land of Kosala and had come to Śrāvastī, where he dwelt in the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta, in the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, and that the wise Gautama himself declared that he had fully and completely awakened to the unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Having heard this, the king went to where the Blessed One was. When he arrived, he exchanged various words of cordial greeting and mutual rejoicing with the Blessed One and then sat down to one side.

Seated to one side, King Prasenajit of Kosala addressed the Blessed One with these words: "O Gautama, I have heard that the wise Gautama proclaims that he himself has fully and completely awakened to the unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Now, Gautama, do those who make such a proclamation not thereby speak disparagingly of the ascetic Gautama? Do they not speak rashly? Do they speak in accordance with what the wise Gautama has said? Do they speak the Dharma? Do they teach the Dharma in a manner consistent with the Dharma? And if an opponent were to come before them to dispute the

matter in a manner consistent with the Dharma, would they not find themselves in a position deserving of censure?"

The Blessed One replied: "Great King, those who speak thus do indeed proclaim the truth. They do not speak disparagingly of me. They do not speak rashly. They speak in accordance with what I have said. They teach the Dharma in a manner consistent with the Dharma. And if an opponent were to come before them to dispute the matter in a manner consistent with the Dharma, they would not find themselves in a position deserving of censure. And why is that? Because I have fully and completely awakened to the unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening."

"That may be so, wise Gautama, and yet I do not believe it. Why is that? O Gautama, consider that there are aged and elderly ascetics and brahmins, such as these: Pūraṇa Kassapa, Makkhali Gosāla the son of Nanda, Sañjaya Belaṭṭhiputta the son of Velaṭṭhi, Pakudha Kaccāyana, Nigaṇṭha Nātaputta, and the naked ascetic Nagnajita — and even they do not declare of themselves that they have fully and completely awakened to the unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. How much less, then, the wise Gautama, who has only recently gone forth and has not long been born?

"Great King, there are four young ones who are not to be looked down upon, not to be belittled. What are the four? Great King, a young one of the warrior-noble class is not to be looked down upon, not to be belittled because of his youth. Great King, a young snake is not to be looked down upon, not to be belittled because of its youth. Great King, a small fire is not to be looked down upon, not to be belittled because of its smallness. Great King, a young monk is not to be looked down upon, not to be belittled because of his youth. And why is that? For even a young monk may become an arhat of great miraculous power and great might.

Having so declared this, the Blessed One, the Sugata, spoke thus —

The Teacher then spoke these further words —

One endowed with matchless warrior-noble birth,
of noble lineage, renowned and pure —
a wise person does not dismiss such a one as merely young,
does not belittle or suppress him.
For a warrior-noble who is learned
may one day attain the royal throne and dominion,
and there exists, through punishment, the power to put to death.

Therefore one should be deeply wary of him,
and thus, to preserve one's own life
and to look after one's own welfare,
one should not dismiss him,
but should take great care in relation to him.

Whether in a village or in the wilderness,
wherever a snake is seen,
a wise person does not dismiss it as merely young,
does not belittle or suppress it.

For as a snake moves about,
among its many and various kinds,
even a young one, when it finds the opportunity,
can seize many men and women.

Therefore, to preserve one's own life
and to look after one's own welfare,
one should not dismiss it,
but should take great care in relation to it.

A fire that consumes greatly, a devourer,
one that has a trail of embers going before it —
even when small, do not dismiss it,
and let the wise not belittle or suppress it.

For by receiving fuel, a small fire
grows from the tiniest thing into something vast.
With blazing tongues of flame it quickly
burns up villages and cities.

Therefore, one who would preserve one's own life
should not dismiss it,
and looking well to one's own welfare,
should take great care in relation to it.

A fire with a trail of embers before it —
when it burns down a thicket of dry wood,
as the days and nights pass over that place,
for some, no new leaves will ever grow.

One who encounters a monk endowed with moral discipline
and sets fire to him —
for such a person, neither children nor grandchildren

will inherit any portion,
and, like the top of a palm tree cut down,
his lineage will before long come to an end.
Therefore, one who would preserve one's own life
should not dismiss such a monk,
and looking well to one's own welfare,
should take great care in relation to him.

The warrior-noble endowed with excellent marks,
the snake, the fire, and likewise
the monk endowed with moral discipline —
let the wise not belittle or suppress any of these.
Therefore, one who would preserve one's own life
should not dismiss them,
and looking well to one's own welfare,
should rightly abandon any such contempt.

Then Prasenajit, king of Kośala, praised and rejoiced in what the Blessed One
had declared, and —

Translator's Notes

- The six named teachers are well-known figures from the Pāli canon usually called the "six heretical teachers" or "six sectarian leaders." Their names appear in Tibetan transliteration that does not perfectly correspond to standard Pāli or Sanskrit forms. The identifications given are the most widely accepted scholarly correspondences: Pūraṇa Kassapa, Makkhali Gosāla, Sañjaya Belaṭṭhiputta, Pakudha Kaccāyana, Nigaṇṭha Nātaputta, and Nagnajita. The Tibetan form for the last name rendered "Nagnajita" is uncertain; it likely refers to the naked ascetic associated with the Ājīvika or Nirgrantha tradition.

The final two lines of the text are a transitional verse formula indicating the Blessed One is about to deliver a teaching in verse; the full verse stanzas do not appear in the passage provided and so are not translated here.

- The verse on the fire burning a thicket and preventing new leaf-growth is a compressed simile: the spiritual devastation visited upon whoever harms a virtuous monk parallels a forest fire so thorough that the trees never recover. The line "for some, no new leaves will ever grow" applies the image to those who caused harm, not to the monk.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, breaking off at "and the Blessed One's —"; this is clearly a deliberate manuscript break or folio-end, continued in the next passage.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.